

A step up: On India and the 2025 Human Development Report

As India **climbs up** HDI rankings, rising inequality **poses** challenges

Amid a **disturbing** rate of **deceleration** in global development and a growing divide between the rich and the poor, India has **inched up** on the Human Development Index. In the 2025 Human Development Report, 'A Matter of Choice: People and Possibilities in the Age of AI', released on Tuesday, India ranks 130 out of 193 countries, from 133 in 2022. It **registered** an HDI value increase to 0.685 in 2023 from 0.676 in 2022. Coming **on the back of** two **debilitating** pandemic years, it can be said that India's recovery has been strong in the three fields HDI measures: "a long and healthy life, access to knowledge and a **decent** standard of living". India's **life expectancy**, at 72 years in 2023, **is** the highest level it has reached since the **inception** of the index in 1990 (58.6 years). **Children**, the report noted, **are** expected to stay in school for 13 years on average, up from 8.2 years in 1990; and **Gross National Income per capita** has risen from \$2,167.22 in 1990 to \$9046.76 in 2023. It gave a **shout out** to programmes such as MGNREGA, the Right to Education Act, the National Rural Health Mission and other initiatives for the improved status, but also **sounded** a word of caution about rising inequality, particularly significant income and gender **disparities**.

The female labour participation rate may have risen to 41.7% in 2023-24, as the Economic Survey of 2024-25 **pointed out**, but a stronger **ecosystem** needs to be built to ensure women join the workforce and are able to **retain** their jobs. There is a **lag** in political representation of women as well with no indication yet when the constitutional **amendments** reserving one-third of legislative seats for women will **come into force**. **Underprivileged** girls and boys still struggle to get an education, and until this **anomaly** is corrected, India's HDI value will not rise. Though the report **highlights** that 13.5 crore (of India's population of 144 crore) "escaped **multidimensional poverty**" between 2015-16 and 2019-21, income and gender inequalities have pulled down India's HDI by 30.7%, "one of the highest losses in the region." The **thrust** of the HDR this year **was** on AI and how human beings may benefit from it on development **parameters**. **India**, it said, **has** been able to retain 20% of AI researchers, up from nearly zero in 2019. **Going forward**, India must **leverage** AI to deliver on many **fronts** from agriculture to health care, education to public service delivery. But it is **imperative** that proper policy and safeguards are **in place** to **thwart** the risk that AI may **deepen existing** inequalities. **[Practice Exercise]**

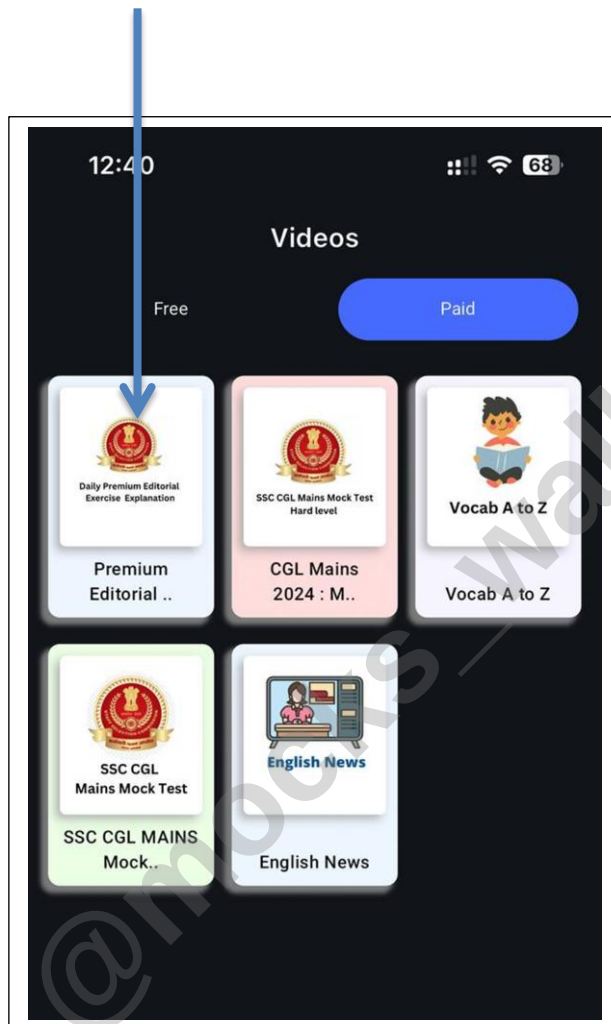
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **A step up** (noun) – improvement, advancement, progress, rise, upgrade
सुधार
2. **Climb up** (phrasal verb) – ascend, rise, progress, go up, scale बढ़ना
3. **Pose** (verb) – present, raise, create, cause, constitute उत्पन्न करना (संकट/प्रश्न आदि)
4. **Amid** (preposition) – during, in the middle of, surrounded by, among, amidst के बीच
5. **Disturbing** (adjective) – troubling, alarming, upsetting, unsettling, distressing
परेशान करने वाला
6. **Deceleration** (noun) – slowdown, reduction, decline, slackening, retardation
मंदी / धीमापन
7. **Inch up** (phrasal verb) – rise slowly, creep upward, gradually increase, move up slightly, advance धीरे-धीरे बढ़ना
8. **Register** (verb) – record, show, indicate, reflect, display दर्ज करना
9. **On the back of** (phrase) – as a result of, following, due to, because of, supported by के कारण / के चलते
10. **Debilitating** (adjective) – weakening, exhausting, draining, disabling, incapacitating कमजोर करने वाला
11. **Decent** (adjective) – adequate, respectable, fair, reasonable, acceptable
उचित
12. **Inception** (noun) – beginning, start, commencement, launch, origin शुरुआत
13. **Gross National Income per capita** (noun) – a measure of a country's average income per person प्रति व्यक्ति सकल राष्ट्रीय आय
14. **Shout out** (phrasal verb) – recognition, praise, mention, appreciation, acknowledgment सार्वजनिक सराहना
15. **Sound** (verb) – announce, warn, alert, declare, express संकेत देना
16. **Disparity** (noun) – inequality, imbalance, difference, divergence, gap असमानता
17. **Point out** (phrasal verb) – indicate, highlight, show, remark, state इंगित करना
18. **Ecosystem** (noun) – system, environment, framework, structure, support system
पारिस्थितिक तंत्र
19. **Retain** (verb) – keep, maintain, preserve, hold, sustain बनाए रखना
20. **Lag** (noun) – delay, gap, shortfall, slowdown, deficiency पिछड़ापन / अंतर
21. **Amendment** (noun) – change, revision, modification, correction, adjustment
संशोधन

22. **Come into force** (phrase) – become effective, be enacted, take effect, start applying, begin operation लागू होना
23. **Underprivileged** (adjective) – poor, disadvantaged, deprived, needy, marginalised वंचित
24. **Anomaly** (noun) – irregularity, inconsistency, abnormality, deviation, oddity विसंगति
25. **Highlight** (verb) – emphasize, underline, point out, showcase, stress जोर देना
26. **Multidimensional** (adjective) – complex, varied, multifaceted, all-encompassing, having many aspects बहुआयामी
27. **Poverty** (noun) – deprivation, indigence, neediness, destitution, scarcity गरीबी
28. **Thrust** (noun) – focus, emphasis, push, core idea, main point मुख्य जोर
29. **Parameter** (noun) – criterion, measure, standard, benchmark, factor मापदंड
30. **Going forward** (phrase) – in the future, from now on, ahead, henceforth, looking ahead आगे चलकर
31. **Leverage** (verb) – utilize, exploit, take advantage of, harness, use effectively लाभ उठाना
32. **Front** (noun) – area, field, domain, sector, aspect क्षेत्र / मोर्चा
33. **Imperative** (adjective) – essential, urgent, necessary, critical, crucial अत्यावश्यक
34. **In place** (phrase) – established, functioning, existing, arranged, implemented लागू / मौजूद
35. **Thwart** (verb) – prevent, hinder, obstruct, block, foil रोकना
36. **Deepen** (verb) – intensify, aggravate, heighten, worsen, strengthen और बढ़ाना
37. **Existing** (adjective) – current, present, prevailing, ongoing, in place मौजूदा

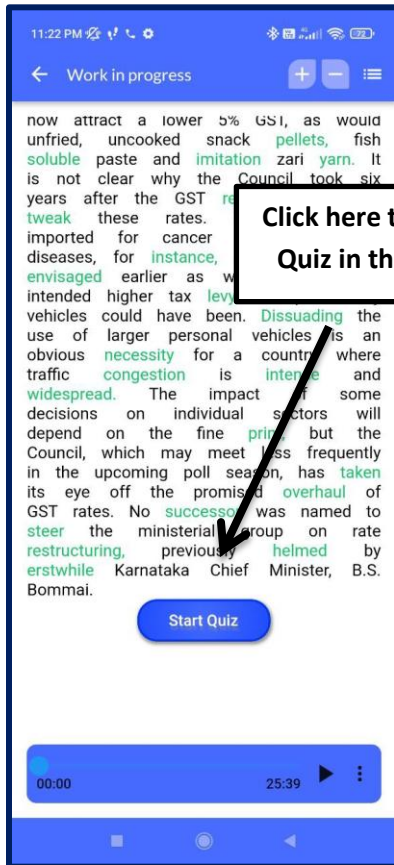
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



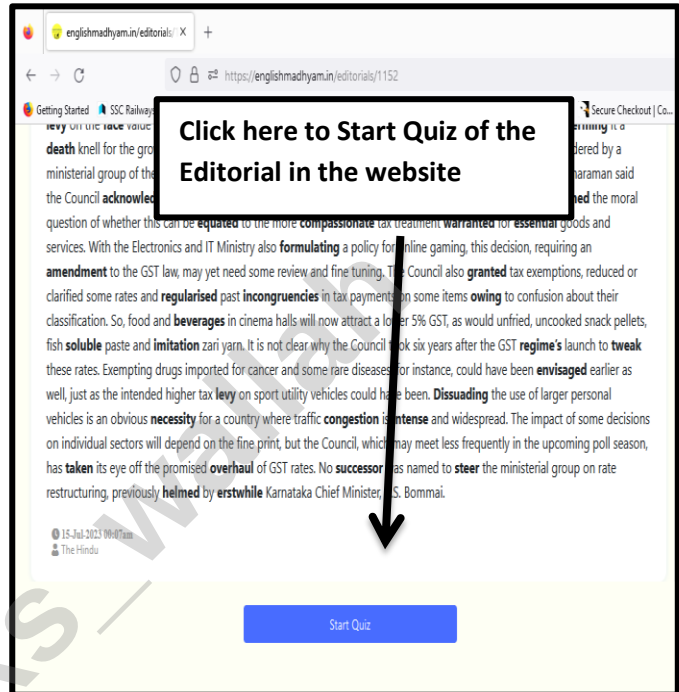
Summary of the Editorial

1. India has improved its HDI rank to 130 in 2025 from 133 in 2022, as per the UN's Human Development Report (HDR).
2. Its HDI value rose from 0.676 (2022) to 0.685 (2023), indicating progress in health, education, and income.
3. The improvement follows recovery from the pandemic's negative impact, reflecting resilience in key sectors.
4. Life expectancy in India has reached 72 years, the highest since HDI tracking began in 1990.
5. Children's expected years of schooling rose to 13 years (from 8.2 in 1990), showing long-term education gains.
6. Gross National Income per capita increased from \$2,167 (1990) to \$9,046 (2023), indicating economic growth.
7. Government schemes like MGNREGA, RTE Act, and the National Rural Health Mission are credited for this progress.
8. However, the report highlights growing inequality, especially in income and gender dimensions.
9. Despite an increase in female labour participation (41.7%), stronger support systems are needed for job retention.
10. Political representation of women remains weak, with no clarity on implementing seat reservations.
11. Many underprivileged children still lack education access, limiting long-term HDI improvement.
12. Between 2015-16 and 2019-21, about 13.5 crore Indians exited multidimensional poverty.
13. Yet, inequality-adjusted HDI shows a 30.7% loss, one of the worst in the region, driven by disparities.
14. The 2025 HDR theme emphasized AI's impact on development, both as an opportunity and risk.
15. India now retains 20% of its AI researchers (up from nearly zero in 2019), but needs strong policies and safeguards to prevent AI from worsening inequality.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



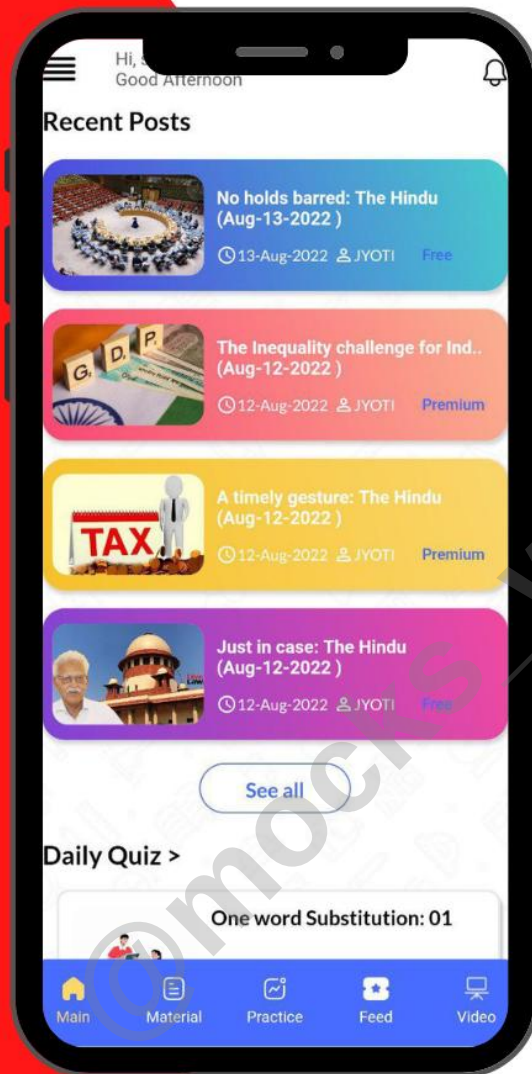
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